unit for land ceiling, definition of family, exemptions from the ceiling and related issues remained undecided for a long time.

In August 1971, a Central Land Reforms Committee (CLRC) was constituted with Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, then minister of food and agriculture, as chairman. It recommended that the ceiling on landholding should be applicable to the family as a whole; the term ‘family’ being defined to include husband, wife and minor children only. CLRC recommended fixing a ceiling for a family of five within a range of 10 to 18 acre for various categories of land. It recommended an absolute ceiling for a family of five at 54 acre. It also recommended withdrawal of exemptions in favour of mechanized and well-managed farms.

These recommendations of CLRC were reviewed by another high-powered committee (HPC), which disagreed with CLRC on the crucial issue of definition of family. The HPC was of the view that ceiling should be applied to a family of five as a unit, consisting of husband, wife and three children, whether major or minor. Major sons were to be included in the family unit of five. It also recommended that if the members in a family were less than five, the ceiling should be reduced by one-fifth per person. Going with the CLRC’s broad thrust, the HPC recommended that exemptions be further restricted by rigidly defining plantations and withdrawing blanket exemptions in case of lands held by trusts, institutions, etc.

Land Ceiling Finally Implemented

The Government of India finally released its guidelines to the states on land ceiling in 1971–72. The Constitution was also amended in 1971 to replace the requirement of paying ‘compensation’ for acquiring land in excess of ceiling by an ‘amount’ to be fixed by laws, which were also made non-challengeable by putting such laws in the Ninth Schedule of the Constitution. The states enacted their land ceiling laws building on these